Losers' Consent and Anti-Systemic Protest: Experimental Evidence from Chile and Estonia

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"Losers' Consent": A Weak Assumption

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- Political elites in stable democracies typically accept electoral losses.
- However, actions by Trump's and Bolsonaro's supporters seriously questioned their acceptance of defeat.
- Research has looked into "losers' consent," focusing on satisfaction, trust, and efficacy.
- Unfortunately, the "losers' consent" literature has not studied the propensity to support anti-systemic protests.

Voters' Commitment:

Electoral Losses and Institutional Heterogeneities

- We analyze the level of system support among electoral losers using novel data from a conjoint experiment in Chile (N=811) and Estonia (N=639).
- We exploit institutional heterogeneities in presidential and parliamentary systems.
- We pre-registered the following hypotheses: link

  H1 Electoral losers favor candidates endorsing anti-systemic actions more than winners
  H2 This tendency is stronger in presidential than in parliamentary systems.

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Electoral Losses and Institutional Heterogeneities

1. Social movements:
   - *"Angry" losers* might be more willing to support anti-systemic politicians. (Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007)
   - Winners (who draw instrumental benefits from the system) should oppose politicians supporting anti-systemic actions.
2. Institutional literature: institutional setups affect differently the costs of losing an election (Lijphart, 2012).
   - **Presidential**: losers have little input outside of the electoral cycle.
   - **Parliamentary**: losers' interests can be represented through a variety of power sharing institutions.

Losers' Consent and Democratic Stability

- Collected novel data from Chile (N=811) and Estonia (N=639) with gender and party sample quotas.
- **Most dissimilar cases**: maximize variance regarding government system (Presidential and Parliamentary).
- **Most similar cases** (two consolidated Third-wave democracies): minimize variance regarding critical V-Dem variables.

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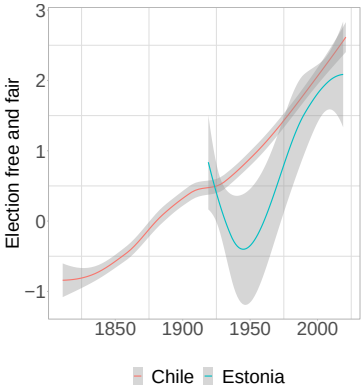

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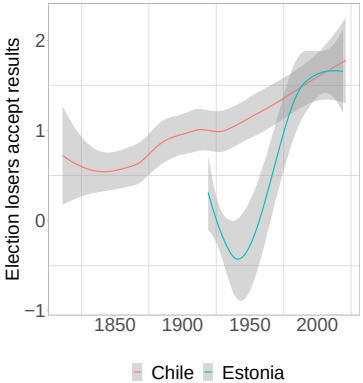

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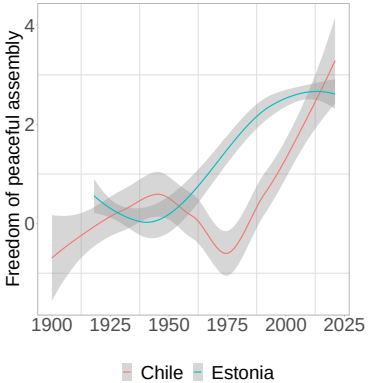

Conjoint Experiment

- Designed an unconstrained, fully randomized conjoint experiment.
- We depart from standard AMCE analyses (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014) and instead compute **subgroup marginal means** (Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley 2020).

Dimension	Attribute Set
Gender	Male, Female.
Age	Younger than 35, Between 35-50, Over 50.
Protest	The candidate OPPOSES anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government, The candidate SUPPORTS anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government
Pensions	The candidate OPPOSES increases in pensions for the elderly, The candidate SUPPORTS increases in pensions for the elderly

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Conjoint Experiment: An Hypothetical Example

- Respondents were asked to choose between two options. For **example**:

Candidate 1	**Candidate 2**
Female Over 50 The candidate OPPOSES anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government The candidate OPPOSES increases in pensions for the elderly	Female Between 35-50 The candidate SUPPORTS anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government The candidate OPPOSES increases in pensions for the elderly
`Please, choose one candidate`	

- Respondents repeated this process 8 times.
- **Every time, cells change their content at random**.

Additional Questions

- Included questions on socio-demographics and support for democracy.
- **Losers/Winners**: asked who respondents voted for **in the last (real) election**.
  - **Chile**: "*Which candidate did you vote for in the 2nd round of the December 2021 presidential election?*"
    `Kast`, `Boric`, `Others` (`Blank/Spoiled`, `I did not vote`, `Prefer not to say`).
  - **Estonia**: "*Which political party did you vote for in the last elections?*"
    `List of Estonian political parties that participated in the March 2023 parliamentary election`.

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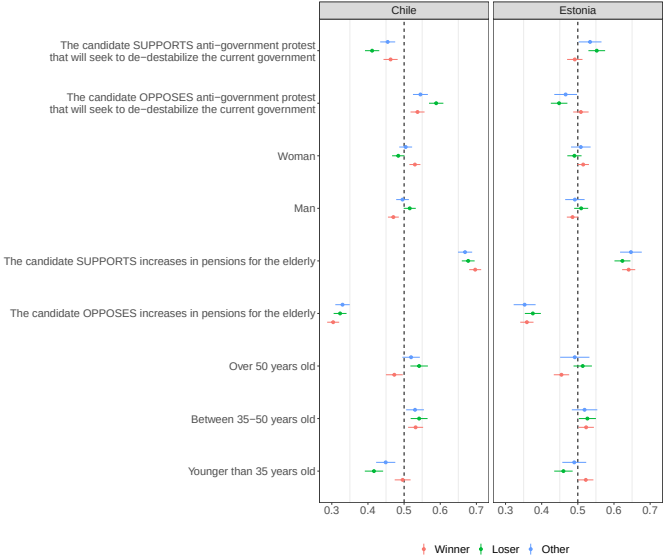
- (Hypothetical) Candidates favoring anti-systemic protests are systematically **supported** by (actual) losers.
- **Losers' Effect**: largely driven by anti-migrant and anti-LGBT extreme right EKRE voters.
- **Disengaged citizens**: did not vote in the last Parliamentary elections favor candidates proposing violent protests.



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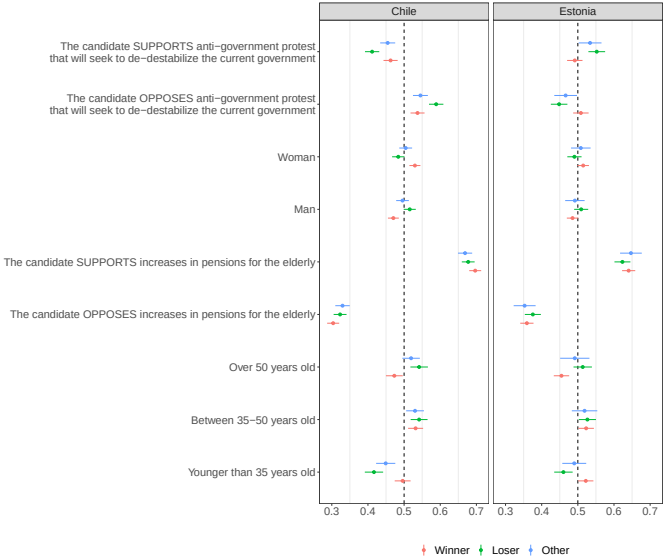

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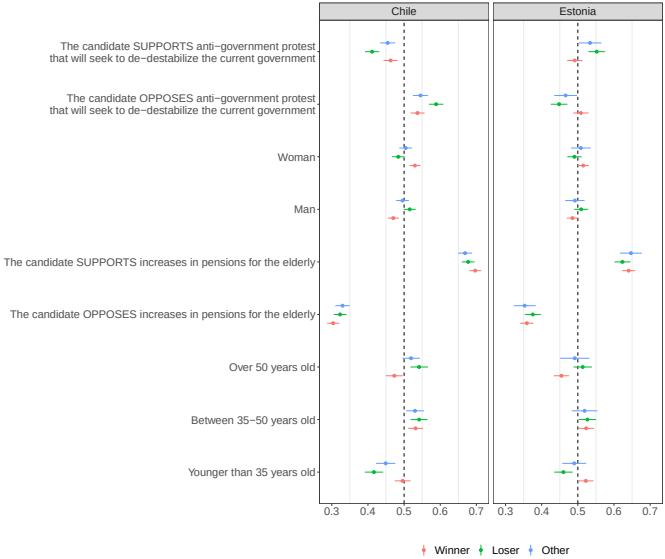

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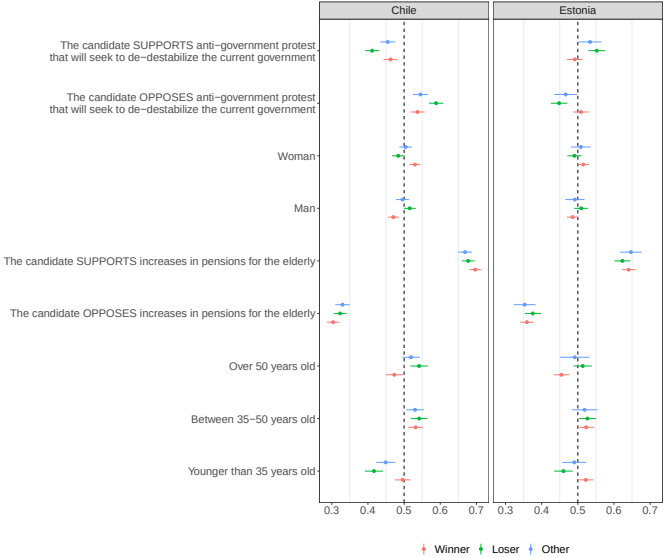

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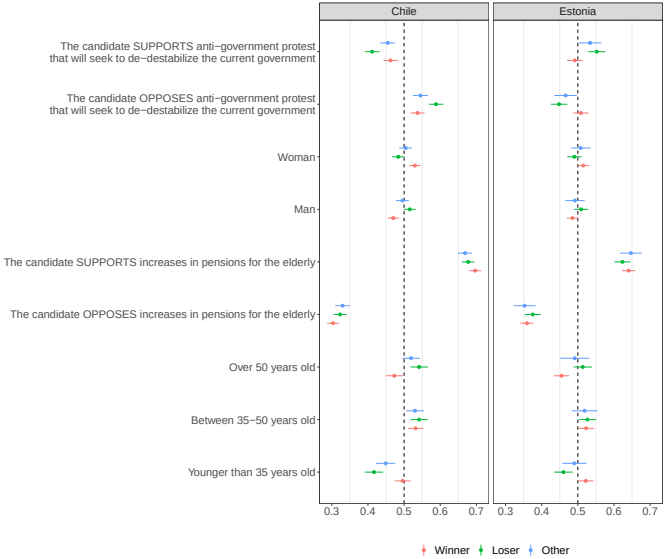

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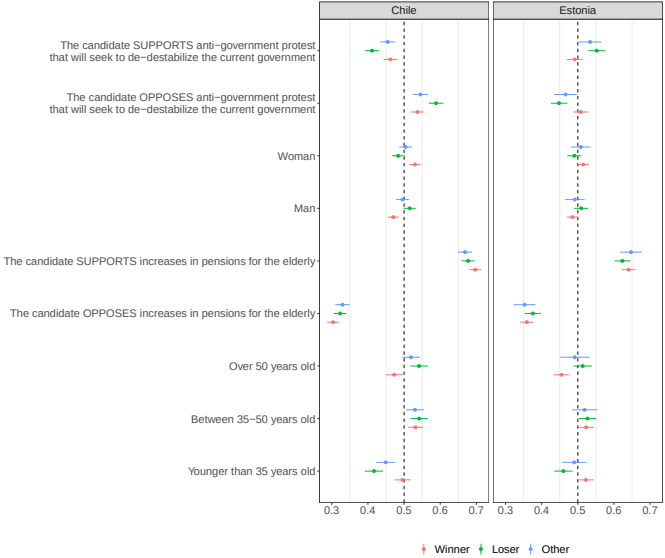

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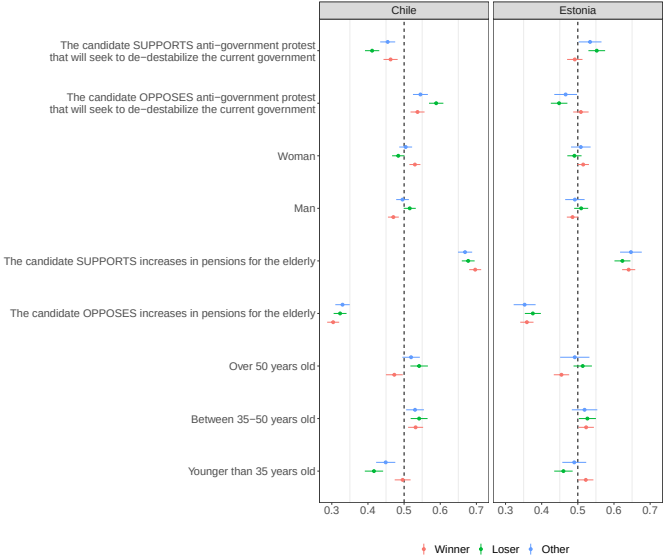

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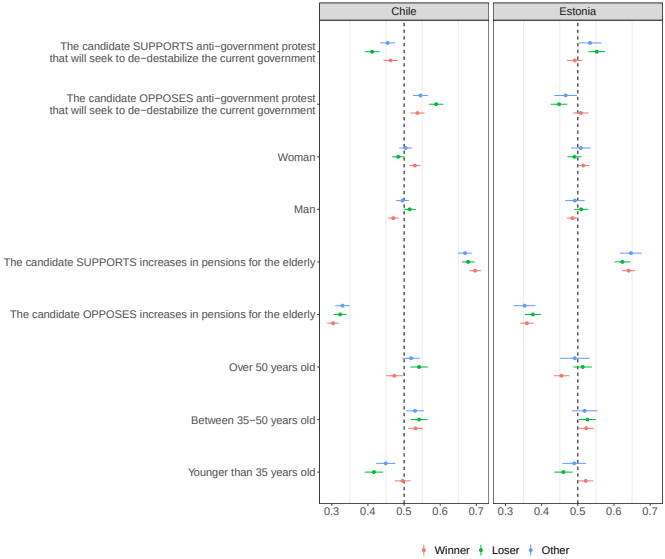

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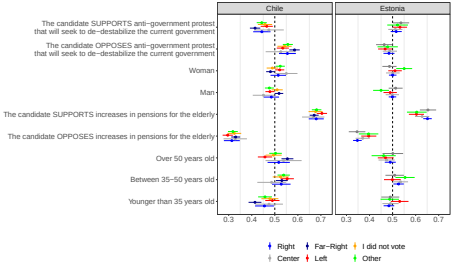
- **Estonia**: loser effects are largely driven by the extreme right.



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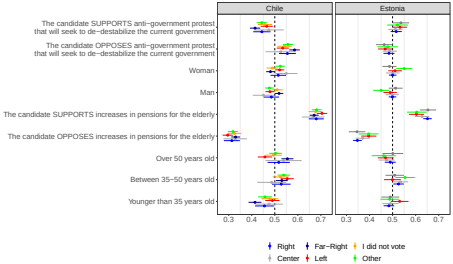

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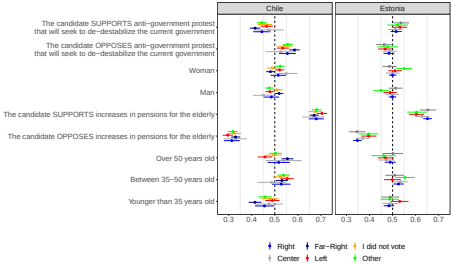

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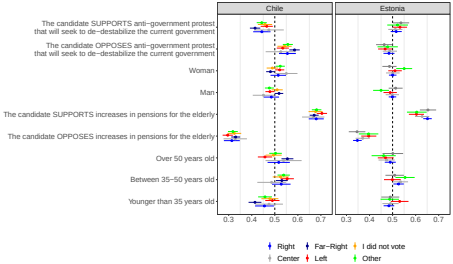

Discussion: More Questions Than Answers

- We hypothesized (and pre-registered) that:
  - H1 *Electoral losers* were *more* willing to support anti-systemic protests.
  - H2 This effect would be *stronger* in Presidential systems
    (because of its zero-sum power sharing structure, **losses are more catastrophic**).
- While we did not find support in favor of our hypotheses, we still found some other interesting results.
  - **Chile**: Extreme-right supporters are less likely to support extreme anti-system protests.
  - **Estonia**: the loser effects are mainly driven by extreme-right supporters.

Thank you

to check updates on this project.